Forty-Five and a Question Mark

Kyle Schwarber · 2026 season recap · UC #60 · `uc-pos-024` · `dp_uc60` v1.0.0 · Phillies Offense

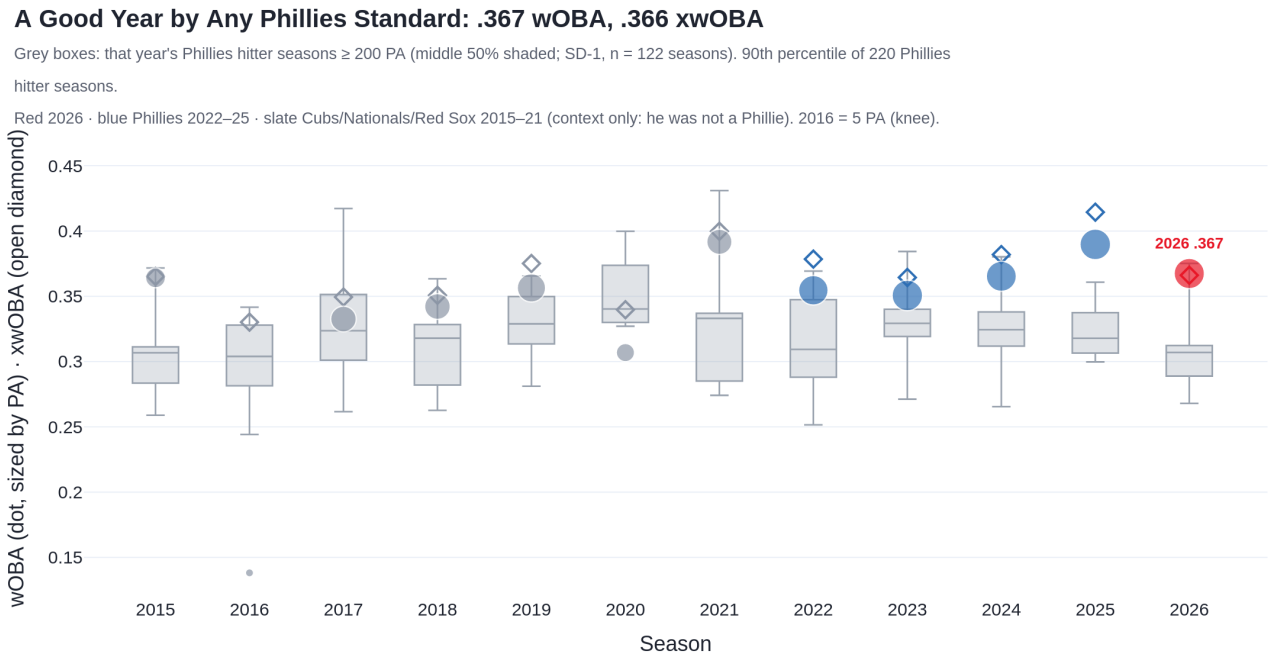
> Kyle Schwarber's 2026: 45 home runs, tied for the MLB lead, and a .367 wOBA that ranks in the 90th percentile of Phillies hitter seasons. Then a second half that made everyone ask about his back.

1 · Bottom line

1. **A good year, not a lost one.** .232/.354/.502, wOBA .367, xwOBA .366. That is his second-best Phillies season by wOBA, and well above the median Phillies 600-PA season (.330 xwOBA).
2. **It turned in July.** First half wOBA .394 on 415 PA; second half .329 on 287. July was the real hole (xwOBA .303). By August and September his expected line (.352, .364) had come back faster than the results.
3. **The back is not visible in the log.** Bat speed before the 6/23 scratch 74.1 mph, after 74.4. The biggest xwOBA split lands on 5/16, 33 games before it. That does not rule an injury out; it says the swing never measurably slowed.
4. **The pop thinned, it didn't vanish.** Barrel rate 15.5%, a hair under his tenure low, but only 10.6% after the break (first half 19.3%). EV p90 108.6, ISO .270 and HR rate all stayed inside his Phillies range.
5. **One real flag: chase.** 26.1% vs 21.4% over 2022–25 (z 4.1), his highest since 2020. Strikeouts rose less (31.3%, z 1.2). And of the cells with enough PA, his damage on righty fastballs fell hardest.

2 · What happened to this man?

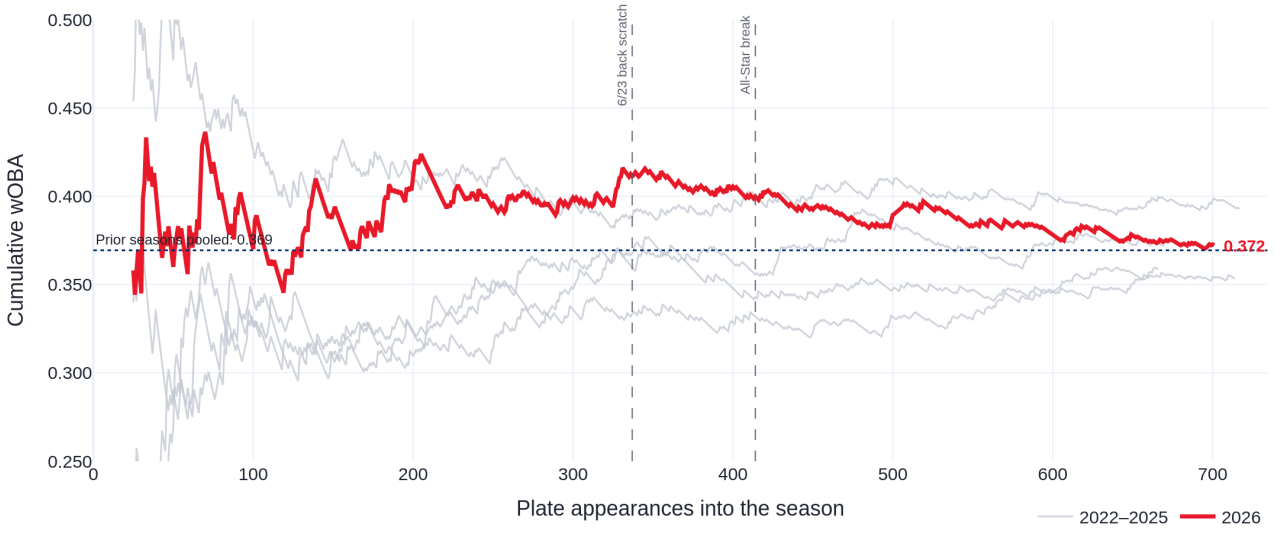
Season	PA	HR	Slash	wOBA	xwOBA	K%	Chase	Barrel	EV p90
2022	666	46	.218/.320/.504	.355	.378	30.0%	21.7%	20.1%	109.6
2023	714	47	.197/.339/.474	.351	.364	30.0%	21.6%	16.4%	108.1
2024	689	38	.247/.361/.484	.365	.382	28.6%	20.9%	15.6%	109.2
2025	719	56	.239/.357/.561	.390	.414	27.4%	21.5%	20.8%	109.8
2026	702	45	.232/.354/.502	.367	.366	31.3%	26.1%	15.5%	108.6



F1 · He was a top-decile Phillies hitter season again: 90th percentile wOBA, 92th xwOBA, 95th barrel rate of 220 seasons since 2015.

Running With His Best Season Until July, Then Settling Into His Second-Best Phillies Year

Cumulative wOBA by PA (cumulative_metric engine, Statcast wOBA weights), regular season; one line per season (the V1 exception); lines start after the 25-PA floor.

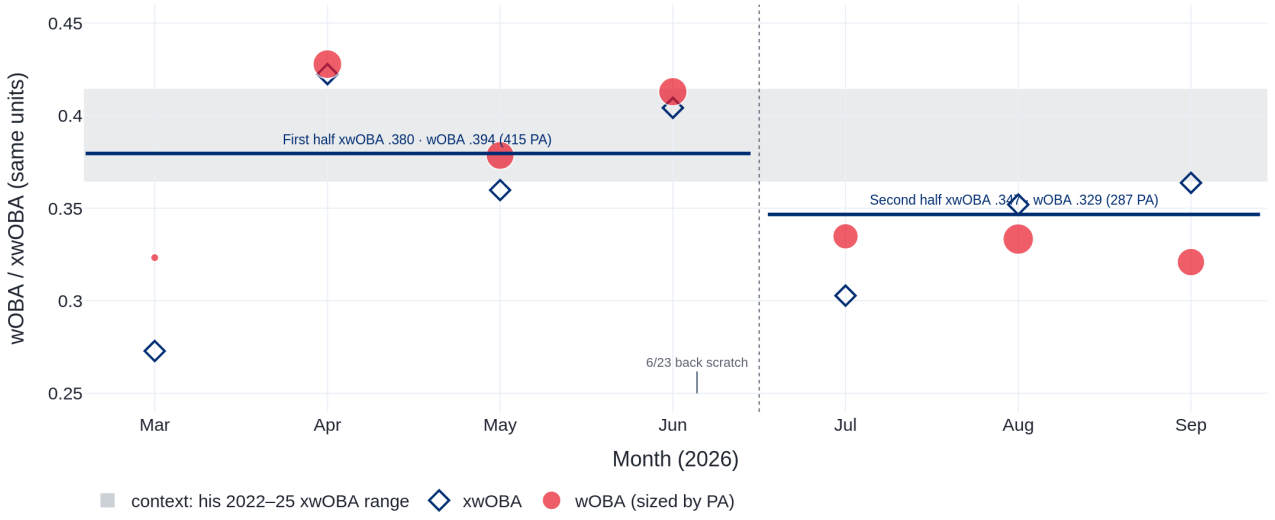


3 · When did it turn?

First half .254/.366/.558 with 32 HR; second half .199/.336/.416 with 13. The second-half strikeout rate fell (34.7% → 26.5%) while chase rose (25.2% → 27.5%): more contact, worse contact (xwOBAcon .548 → .405).

The Turn Came in July, and the Expected Line Came Back Before the Results Did

2026 by calendar month (the first half runs through 7/12, so it includes 11 July games). Dots sized by PA; open diamonds = xwOBA; navy bars = half-season xwOBA; grey band = his 2022–25 season xwOBA range.

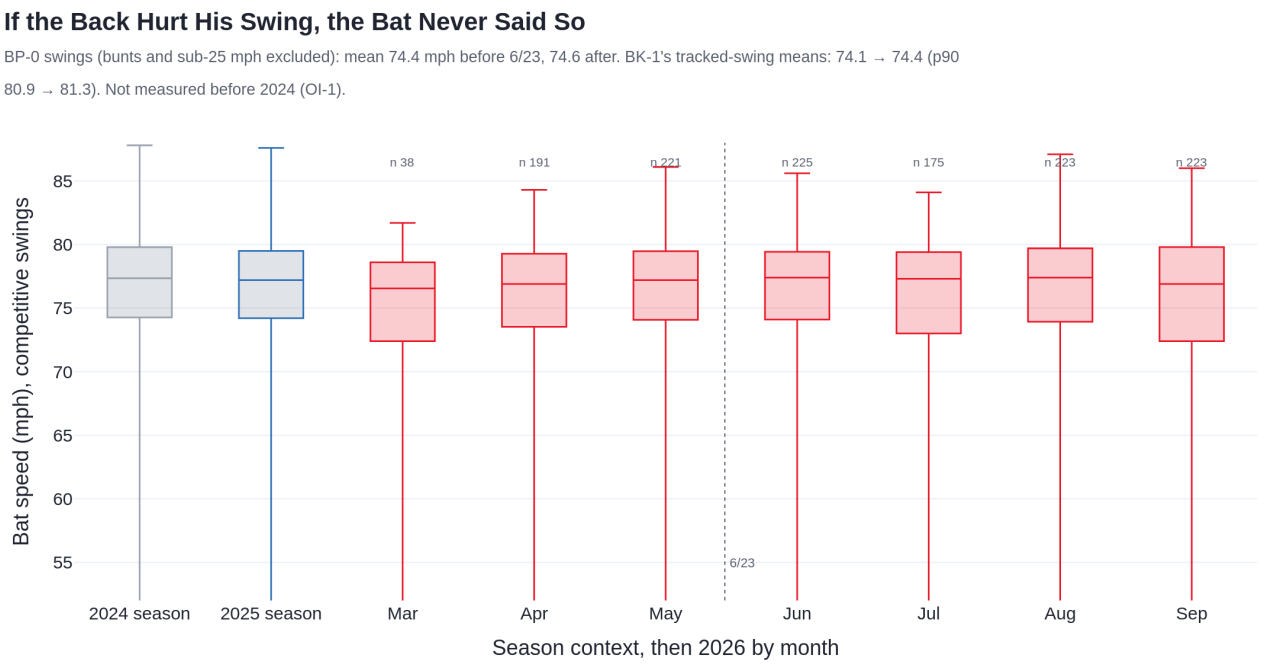


4 · It was his back?

Graded: NOT VISIBLE IN THE LOG (BK-1, pre-registered). The one documented event is a late scratch on 6/23 at Washington ("lower back tightness … while he was trying to swing"). He missed one game, pinch-hit the next day, and started 6/25, with no IL stint. Absences in the log, every one reconciled: 5/18 illness (stomach) · 5/19 illness (stomach) · 5/20 illness (stomach) · 6/23 back (late scratch) · 7/28 illness (GI) · 7/29 illness (GI).

BK-1	Before 6/23	After 6/25
PA	338	363
wOBA / xwOBA	.404 / .387	.332 / .346

BK-1	Before 6/23	After 6/25
Bat speed mean / p90 (mph)	74.1 / 80.9	74.4 / 81.3
Swing length (ft)	7.44	7.45
EV p90 (mph)	109.1	108.2
Barrel % / hard-hit %	21.1% / 52.0%	10.7% / 46.9%
Chase / whiff	24.7% / 34.5%	27.4% / 31.8%
xwOBAcon	.556	.424



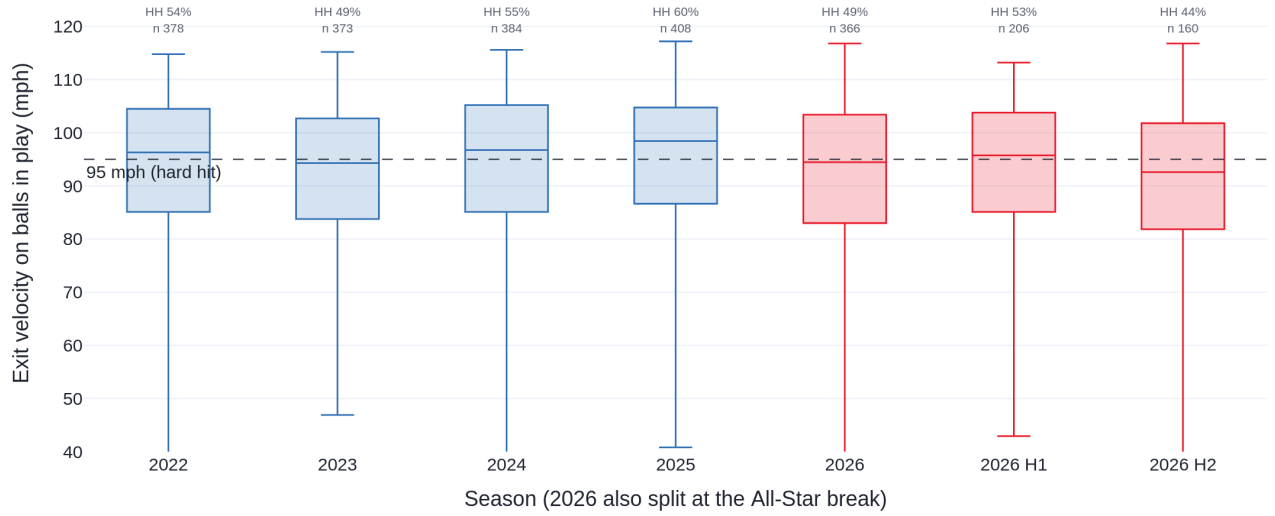
What fell after the scratch was **damage, not speed**: barrels halved and xwOBAcon fell .556 → .424, on the same bat speed and swing length. That pattern is consistent with a launch-angle and decision problem (UC33's midseason finding), and it neither proves nor rules out discomfort. The biggest xwOBA break in the season sits at 5/16, 33 games before the scratch; wOBA's sits at 8/15.

5 · Did he lose his pop?

Graded: PARTLY (POP-1: 1 of 4 legs at his 2022–25 low).

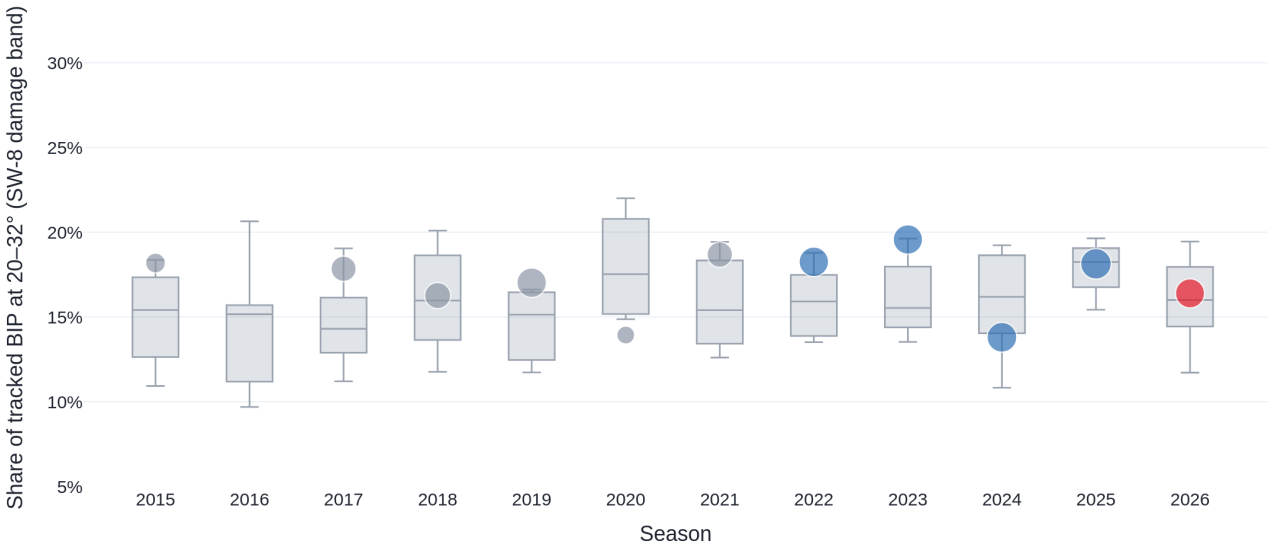
The Pop Didn't Vanish, It Thinned Out After the Break

Boxes = middle 50% of exit velocity on BIP. Barrel rate 15.5% for the year, the lowest of his Phillies tenure by a hair (2024 15.6%); first half 19.3%, second 10.6%.



Fewer Balls in His Damage Band: 16.4% in 2026, After 18.1% in 2025

UC33's SW-8 band (20° < launch angle ≤ 32°), where his batted balls do the most damage. Dots sized by tracked BIP; grey boxes = Phillies hitter seasons that year.



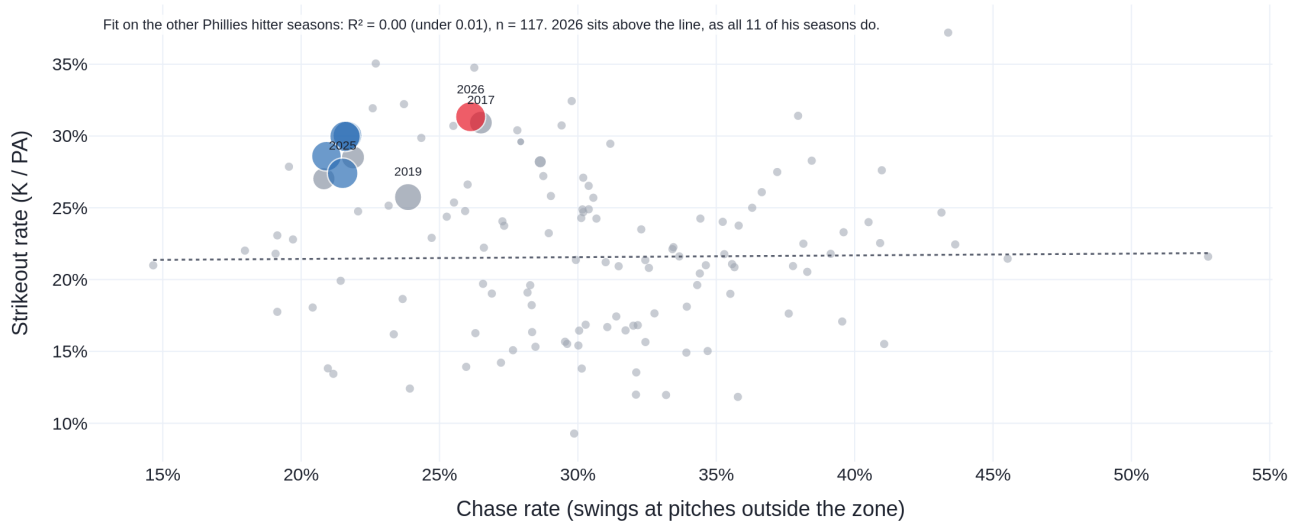
His homers were the softest and shortest of his Phillies years (UC58, HP-01–05 there). Here the whole contact profile shows the same thing more mildly: the middle 50% of exit velocity barely moved, while the second-half box slid down.

6 · Should we be concerned?

Graded: NOT SUPPORTED on the pre-registered bar (CN-1). His xwOBA (.366) sits above his own 2022–25 low and well above the Phillies ≥ 600-PA median. The process leg needs both strikeouts and chase to move beyond noise; only chase did (z 4.1; strikeouts z 1.2).

Chase Rose to 26.1%, but Chase Barely Predicts Strikeouts Here

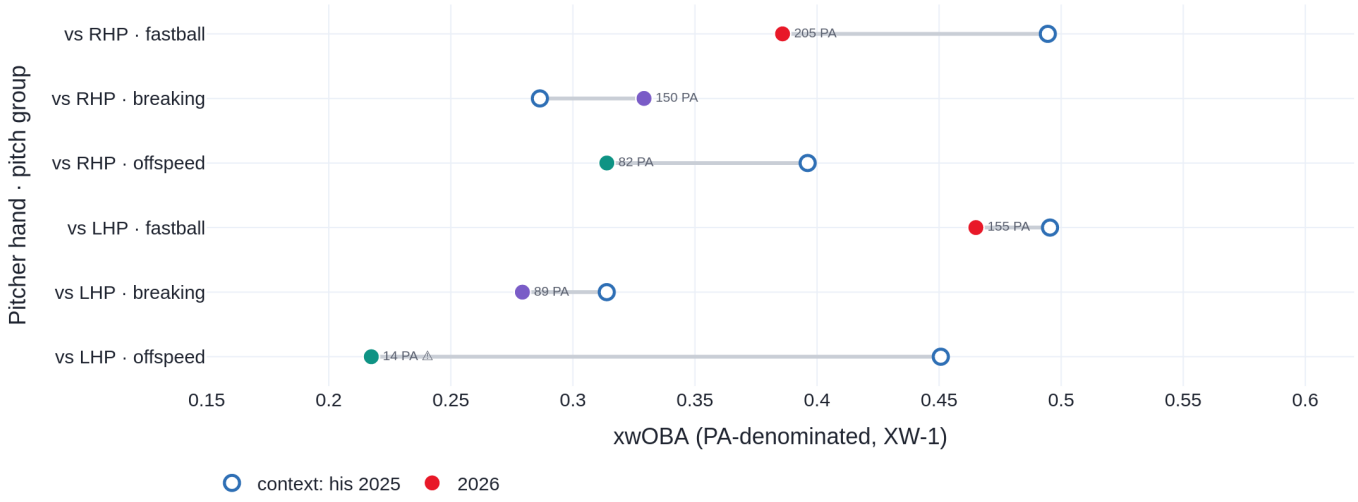
His seasons ≥ 200 PA (sized by PA) over every other Phillies hitter season since 2015. Every one of his seasons sits above the line: his strikeouts come from whiffs, not chase.



Across 117 other Phillies hitter seasons, chase explains almost none of strikeout rate (R^2 0.00). Every season of his sits above the line, so his strikeouts come from whiffs, not from chasing. That makes 2026's chase jump a separate problem to fix.

The Leak Was Righty Fastballs: xwOBA .495 → .386

Each row: open blue = 2025, filled = 2026 (red fastball, violet breaking, teal offspeed). ⚠ = a season under 30 PA in that cell (too few to call).



7 · Three things for 2027

1. **Chase, first.** Bring it back toward his 2022–25 21.4%. It is the only process number that moved beyond noise.
2. **Righty fastballs.** xwOBA on them fell from .495 to .386 (205 PA). That is where the 2025 version of him lived.
3. **The damage band.** 16.4% of his tracked contact landed at 20–32°, after 18.1% in 2025. It is the launch-angle drift UC33 flagged at midseason, and it never fully came back.

8 · The notebook graded

HP	Claim	Grade	Evidence
HP-01	"Should we be concerned? Perhaps..."	**NOT SUPPORTED**	xwOBA .366 vs his 2022-25 low .364 and the Phillies ≥600-PA median .330 (n 33): above both. K% 31.3% vs 29.0% (z 1.22, LEANS); chase 26.1% vs 21.4% (z 4.06, CHANGED). One process flag (chase), not two

HP	Claim	Grade	Evidence
HP-02	"It was his back?"	**NOT VISIBLE IN THE LOG**	Bat speed 74.1 → 74.4 mph (p90 80.9 → 81.3); EV p90 109.1 → 108.2 (bar 1.5 drop). Best xwOBA split 2026-05-16 (33 team games from 6/23; bar 15). Damage did fall after 6/23 (barrel 21.1% → 10.7%, xwOBAcon .556 → .424), but the swing itself did not slow
HP-03	"Did he lose his pop?"	**PARTLY**	1 of 4 legs at/below his 2022-25 low: barrel 15.5% (low 15.6%) YES; EV p90 108.6 (low 108.1) no; ISO .270 (low .237) no; HR/PA .064 (low .055) no. Second-half barrel 10.6% vs first 19.3%. UC58: his homers were the softest and shortest of his Phillies years
HP-04	1st half .254/.367/.560 → 2nd half .199/.336/.416	**SUPPORTED**	House log: H1 .254/.366/.558 (gap ≤ 0.002: definition gap, CI cut 'through the break'), H2 .199/.336/.416 (exact)
HP-05	K% 31.4%, his highest since 2017; 220 strikeouts	**SUPPORTED (stronger)**	220 K; K% 31.3% on 702 PA (31.4% on 701 PA under PA-X1). Highest prior full season (≥ 200 PA): 2017 at 30.9%, so 2026 is a career high among full seasons, not just a high since 2017
HP-06	Chase 26.1%, up from 21.5%, highest since 2020	**SUPPORTED**	26.1% vs 21.5%; latest season at or above it: 2020 (house definition matches Savant here)
HP-07	September .172 AVG, .710 OPS	**SUPPORTED**	.172 / .710 OPS; xwOBA in September .364 vs wOBA .321
HP-08	32 HR through the break, 13 after	**SUPPORTED**	32 / 13

Candid caveats

- **No medical claim.** BK-1 tests one documented event (the 6/23 scratch, one game missed). The log can show a swing; it cannot show a back.
- **Illness absences** (5/18–5/20 stomach, 7/28–7/29 GI) bracket the back scratch; 6 games missed in all, every one reconciled.
- **Bat tracking starts in 2024** (bat speed) and 2025 (swing path). Earlier seasons are 'not measured', never imputed (OI-1).
- **Two wOBA scales.** Season and monthly wOBA use the house weights (K57). The cumulative chart (F2) uses Statcast's own weights through `cumulative_metric`, so its end point (.372) differs slightly.
- **Context pools are Phillies-only** (SD-1: 122 hitter seasons ≥ 200 PA since 2015), not MLB-wide. His 2015–21 seasons are plotted against that year's Phillies hitters for context only.
- **Small cells.** The lefty-offspeed cell has 14 PA and is marked too few to call.

Visual standard (Tier 3, V1–V7): 8 figures audited by `phillies_dp.recap_viz.audit`, 0 FAIL. Comparison set, eras and helpers are the shared registries SD-1/SD-2/SD-3. Carry-ins (MLB.com, Yahoo/SB Nation, NBC Sports Philadelphia, 6abc/AP, Roundtable) are quoted, never computed on. Source: Statcast via the house log, regular season unless stated; 2026 WC: 13 PA, 1 HR (off Dylan Lee).